

# A new and aggressive opponent

According to a survey by World Athletics undertaken two years ago, three-quarters of athletes have been **directly impacted** by climate change. This is a startling figure.

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**A**thletes around the world have a new and aggressive opponent to deal with. Even international sport, where competitors are younger, fitter, stronger, better looked after, is beginning to suffer. The enemy is extreme heat. And it is not affecting just performance, but health too. Awareness is of the problem not always followed by action, however.

At the Shanghai Open tennis recently, players were forced to retire; Novak Djokovic vomited in successive matches as the conditions got to him. Emma Raducanu quit her match with dizziness in Wuhan as players “wilted in brutal conditions” of high temperature and humidity. One official asked, “You want a player to die on the court?” He was echoing what Daniil Medvedev had spelt out so decisively at the U.S. Open in 2023: “One player gonna die.”

The ATP said in a statement that player safety was its top priority and that it is considering such a policy. Note the tense: present continuous. The ATP doesn’t have an overall heat policy in place unlike the Grand Slams or the WTA. The decision is left to the local authorities during a tournament.

It isn’t just the players. Last year, assistant referee Humberto Panjoj collapsed during a football match between Canada and Peru in Kansas City after being positioned in the direct sun. He had to be stretchered off. A study earlier this year has warned that afternoon matches at the 2026 World Cup in the U.S. could expose players and fans to “potentially dangerous levels of heat.”

The 2022 World Cup football in Qatar had to be played



**Major concern:** At the Shanghai Open tennis recently, players were forced to retire; Novak Djokovic vomited in successive matches as the conditions got to him. AP

in winter. Most matches were held late evening, local time. In the U.S. World Cup, matches are scheduled for the afternoon, to cater to Europe’s television audience (which also means sponsors with interests in that region). International sport is squeezed between the climate crisis and television business. According to research by the Queen’s University, Belfast, almost 90% of the North American stadiums hosting the World Cup could face potentially dangerous levels of heat. Spectators are in danger too.

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*The Economist* recently summed up the effect of climate crisis on sport: “Beyond sweeping planetary changes, seemingly small variations in temperature make a huge difference to athletes’ performance. The sapping effect of warm weather is well known, and is why they often try to acclimatise themselves before competitions in hot places. Even then, though, only so much adaptation is possible: higher temperatures hasten dehydration, cause glucose to be broken down more quickly and reduce the amount of oxygen sent to the muscles (the body has to prioritise sending blood to the skin in order to cool itself down).”

If that is the case with professional sport, what of amateur sport which do not have the same resources? And lower down the pecking order, what of the casual knockabout games among half-fit, unfit or untrained players?